If anyone had doubts about Grover's interest in getting the deal done, one must have been convinced of his patriotism by his very presence here. Taking commission was a perfectly legal and professional thing in France and many other space-faring countries, but India still frowns at people who facilitate path-breaking partnerships. We call them middlemen, a word often uttered with disdain. It was perfectly legit for Grover to have taken a commission from SEP for the Viking-Vikas deal, it remains unknown to me if he ever saw this as a business opportunity.

Now, as we stood wondering about the thanksgiving, Grover spoke: 'I have a request, Mr Nambi. If you permit me, I will have the pleasure of getting some champagne for all of us.'

I was embarrassed. Here was this man who was neither bound by duty nor lured by any personal benefit offering to host the celebration of our success—something that our organisation or the government should be doing. Before I could gather my thoughts, H R S Mani intervened.

'For good things in life,' Mani told Grover, 'you don't need permission.'

Everyone laughed. And champagne flowed. Grover remembered the day at Windsor Manor in Bangalore when SEP head Souffle had almost called off the deal, and I had asked Grover to employ his marketing skills to win the contract for India. I remembered the day I had first met Grover, at Le Lido in Paris, where he sponsored a bottle of champagne for all the 2,000 guests of the evening. This man had passion.

That evening, back at Hotel Meridian in Paris where we stayed, I flashed a thumbs up to the lobby manager as I walked past him to my room. Over the days of 'waiting for the Vernon wind,' we had struck a friendship. After returning disappointed for many days, today he got the message. He called me on the intercom.

'Felicitations,' he said, and offered to send some champagne.

I thanked him and said no to the champagne. 'We had enough of it,' I said. 'But if you insist, we don't mind some whiskey.'

We binged, egging each other on to have some more liquid propulsion. N K Gupta, the turbo pump man, was a teetotaler. He laughed at our